

Dietary Guidelines for Indians (2024)

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Introduction

The Dietary Guidelines for Indians 2024, drafted by the ICMR-NIN, aim to promote healthy diets and lifestyles across all age groups. The guidelines respond to the dual burden of malnutrition and the rising prevalence of non-communicable diseases (NCDs) like diabetes, hypertension, and obesity in India.

1. Eat a Variety of Foods

A balanced diet requires a diverse intake of nutrients. The guidelines recommend consuming foods from at least 5 to 7 food groups daily. Cereals and millets should not contribute to more than 45% of total daily energy intake. The rest should come from pulses, eggs, flesh foods, and dairy.

2. Focus on Vegetables, Fruits and Legumes

At least half the plate should consist of vegetables, fruits, roots, and tubers. Green leafy vegetables are particularly important for micronutrients like iron, folate, and vitamins. Consuming liberal amounts of these helps prevent chronic diseases and addresses micronutrient deficiencies.

3. Limit Salt, Sugar, and Fats

Salt intake should be restricted to less than 5 grams per day to manage blood pressure. Added sugars should be limited to less than 5% of total daily energy intake. Children below two years of age should not be given added sugars. Use fats and oils in moderation. Limit saturated fats and avoid trans fats entirely.

4. Avoid Ultra-Processed Foods (UPFs)

The 2024 guidelines strongly caution against Ultra-Processed Foods (UPFs) and High Fat, Sugar, and Salt (HFSS) foods. These products are heavily altered industrially and contain additives that disrupt normal metabolic functions and drive the obesity epidemic.

5. Maternal and Child Nutrition

Ensure extra food and adequate healthcare for pregnant and lactating women to support fetal and infant development. Promote exclusive breastfeeding for the first six months of life, followed by the introduction of home-based semi-solid complementary foods, while continuing breastfeeding up to two years or beyond.

6. Physical Activity and Lifestyle

A healthy diet must be coupled with an active lifestyle. Regular physical activity helps maintain energy balance, prevents weight gain, and reduces the risk of NCDs. The guidelines also recommend avoiding tobacco and alcohol completely, as they negate the benefits of a healthy diet.